

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Communications outage

COMMUNICATIONS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Conserve phone battery, try short texts for nonurgent check-ins and use a battery radio for official information. For immediate danger, try calling local emergency services; text-to-911 availability varies. Do not travel into danger just to find signal.

Do now.

**Check alternatives**

01

Try a safe available landline, another carrier or Wi-Fi calling if configured and functioning.

**Keep messages short**

02

Send your location, status and next check-in time to your out-of-area contact.

**Protect battery**

03

Lower brightness, enable low-power mode and limit unnecessary use.

**Use the meeting plan**

04

If networks fail completely, follow the agreed safe meeting and contact arrangements.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Write a short message with your status, location and next check-in time; try it periodically rather than draining the battery with constant retries. Use your agreed meeting plan only when the route is safe. Do not split up to hunt for signal.

Watch for.

A message sent is not necessarily delivered. Do not assume emergency texting is supported everywhere.

People & practical needs.

Give each person a written contact card and explain what to do if separated. Plan for hearing, vision, language and literacy needs. Keep live family locations and identity details off public posts even when a message seems urgent.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Keep paper contact lists, offline maps and a radio. Arrange check-in times before a crisis.

Questions in the field.

Is one failed app the whole network?

Try the simplest available channel without repeated battery-draining attempts: a short text, a checked Wi-Fi connection or a prearranged contact. A local internet outage and a cellular outage may require different workarounds; do not assume every service has failed.

What if messages cannot be delivered?

Use the household's prearranged meeting and check-in plan rather than making unplanned trips to find a signal. Keep a radio or other verified warning source if available. Record unconfirmed information separately from actual contact.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Communications outage](#) · [official guidance](#)

<https://www.fcc.gov/emergency>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/communications-outage/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.